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TRACK STARS

Dressed as bananas and dinosaurs, these costume-clad Chicagoans go viral for chasing CTA trains

By Audrey Pachuta | CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Standing on a second-story Bronzeville balcony Sunday evening, a couple watched from above as the grassy area between their apartment building and the CTA Green Line tracks came to life in a way it never had before.

They saw people of all ages come flocking in costumes: one dressed as an inflatable dinosaur and others as bananas, Michael Jackson and a gingerbread girl. Looking down at the gathering of around 30, they could see smaller groups of people forming, as if they were organizing themselves for a task greater than flaunting unusual wardrobes.

“What in God’s name are you doing?” one of the onlookers shouted.

“We’re chasing the train,” the man dressed as Michael Jackson yelled back.

And so the race began.

It’s been a little over two months since 25-year-old Charlie Clerk perfected his social media bit: summoning swarms of costume-clad Chicagoans to run absurd lengths from outside CTA stations toward arriving “L” trains. This spring, the demand for his comedic content skyrocketed, drawing nearly 350,000 followers and video view counts in the millions on his Instagram account, @sidequestre.

Known by viewers and fellow video participants as “Tre,” Clerk said he works tirelessly to choreograph the perfect train chases. So far, his most viral video had more than 70 million views and showed him — dressed as the Grinch and accompanied by his trademark orange dinosaur — chasing down a train at the Orange Line’s Halsted station.

Online, his videos look chaotic, but behind the scenes, the project’s ringleader spends his free time poring over satellite maps, visiting potential chase sites and crafting the necessary recording angles. Not to mention purchasing an ever-growing

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Above: People run to catch the Green Line train at the Indiana CTA station in the Grand Boulevard neighborhood on Sunday.
EILEEN T. MESLAR/CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Attacks escalate in Gulf region

US strikes threaten to end stalled negotiation efforts

By Jon Gambrell and Michelle L. Price
ASSOCIATED PRESS

DUBAI, United Arab Emirates — The U.S. military said Wednesday it has begun another round of strikes against Iran after President Donald Trump said more were coming. The escalating attacks threatened to derail efforts to end the war, with Trump warning that Tehran would “pay the price” for stalled negotiations.

U.S. Central Command said in a social media post that the military is striking “multiple targets in Iran” and that it’s being done “in response to Iran’s unwarranted and continued aggression.”

The second day of American strikes came hours after Bahrain, Kuwait and Jordan — all of which host U.S. troops — came under Iranian fire. It was the third time this week that back-and-forth strikes have tested a two-month ceasefire. They also came a day after the U.S. struck Iran following the crash of an Army helicopter near the Strait of Hormuz that Trump blamed on the Islamic Republic.

Trump urged Iran to sign a deal to end the war.

Earlier Wednesday, the U.S. military said it had fired on an oil tanker attempting to transport oil from Iran in violation of its blockade on Iranian ports.

Trump’s comments underlined his whipsaw approach to the war; earlier this week he suggested a deal to end the conflict could be reached in a matter of days.

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‘I LOVE THE INFLATION’: Trump defends rising costs as, amid war in Iran, energy prices send inflation to highest point in three years. **Business, Page B2**

Library, school leaders lay into county over tax payout delays

By A.D. Quig
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Suburban library and school district officials laid into Cook County leaders Wednesday over the fact last year’s late property tax bills cost them millions of dollars, with another lengthy delay looming this year.

At a long-anticipated Cook County Board meeting on the still-spiraling problems with the county’s property tax collections and payouts, Diana McCluskey, chief school business official for Community Consolidated School District 15 in Palatine, testified that her district had lost “approximately \$4 million due to this unfortunate situation. Where are we going to make that up from? We aren’t a corporation.”

“Also I’m expecting \$10 million more in property tax receipts this fiscal year. We received nothing in the entire month of May.... If any of us speaking here from the school districts did anything close to what is happening here, we would lose our jobs,” McCluskey said.

But county officials offered them few clear explanations for the ongoing delays and problems. After several hours

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GENERAL ASSEMBLY

Bill to ban ‘junk fees’ on renters awaits approval from Pritzker

By Jack O’Connor
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

SPRINGFIELD — Sharon Gardner was paying her rent. But her Hanover Park apartment owner continued to pile up charges against her.

With eviction threats mounting, Gardner was told she owed more than \$3,300 in unexpected fees — a \$50 monthly charge for cable internet she never received, \$5 a month for pest control, a \$300 move-in fee she hadn’t been told about, and a \$200 monthly charge for a month-to-month lease even though management never sent her a new lease agreement despite her repeated requests.

“I was afraid every month that the sheriff was going to knock down my door and throw me out. I was still paying my rent,” Gardner said. “I wrote email after email. Can you send me an updated ledger? Can you tell me what’s going on? Why are you evicting me?”

After an eviction attempt, Gardner even-



Sharon Gardner at her home in the Blu Apartments on June 4 in Hanover Park. Illinois lawmakers passed legislation this spring banning many hidden rental fees, or “junk fees.” Gardner received \$10,000 for settling a case that largely centered on how arbitrary the month-to-month fees for her were. **JOHN KONSTANTARAS/FOR THE CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

tually received \$10,000 for settling a case that largely centered on how arbitrary the month-to-month fees were. But she said all the charges and the way her management company treated her and other tenants were “not fair.”

Her experience may soon become illegal in Illinois.

Democratic lawmakers passed legislation this spring to ban many of these hidden rental charges — often called “junk fees” —

while requiring other mandatory fees to be disclosed on the first page of a leasing agreement. The bill awaits Gov. JB Pritzker’s signature, who did not respond to requests for comment.

“What people need to understand is junk fees are fees not for landlords’ actual costs. They are fees for the sole purpose of making the tenant pay more money for nothing,”

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CPS chief defends trans policies

Republican lawmakers echoed Trump attacks, grilling Chicago Public Schools CEO Macquiline King during a tense hearing Wednesday. **Chicagoland, Page A2**

Reward offered in cross burning

A burning cross in Chicago’s Grant Park on Tuesday sparked outrage among some locals who recognized the historic symbol of racism. **Chicagoland, Page A3**

‘Broadview Six’ fallout grows

A judge overseeing a high-profile COVID testing fraud case has ordered a hearing into potential misconduct by the U.S. attorney’s office. **Chicagoland, Page A5**

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